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Interkulturelle Kommunikation und heterogene Teams Lecture Notes – 01: Foundation, Teams, Competences



Introduction

Overview of intercultural and heterogeneous teams.



Diversity Dimensions

Exploration of Diversity dimensions and frameworks.



Communication

Communication strategies for diverse teams.



Team Dynamics

Understanding team dynamics and conflict.



Leadership

Leadership approaches for intercultural teams.



Collaboration Tools

Technology for global teams.



Case Studies

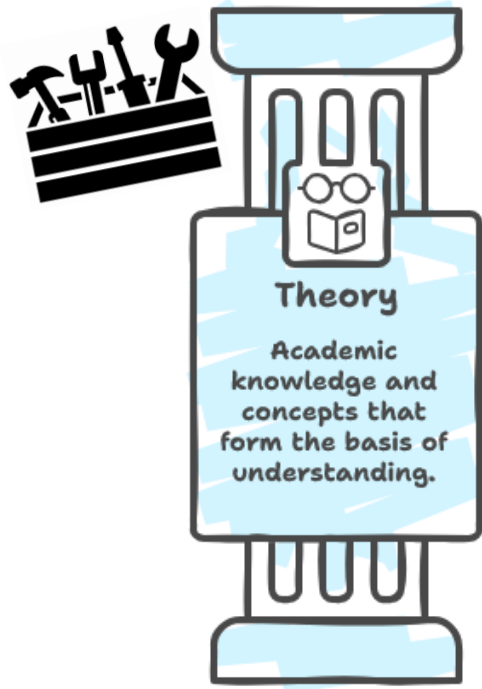
Examination of case studies and best practices.



Capstone Activity

Final project and reflection on learning.

How ? Expansion of your competence, cont.

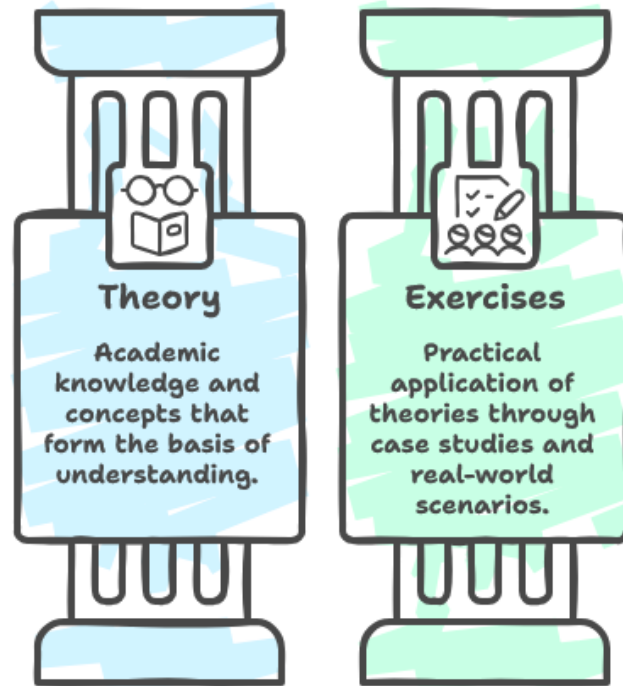


Theory = Knowledge (The Toolbox)

The academic foundation. It includes:

- Theories
- Models
- Methods
- Tools

How ? Expansion of your competence, cont.

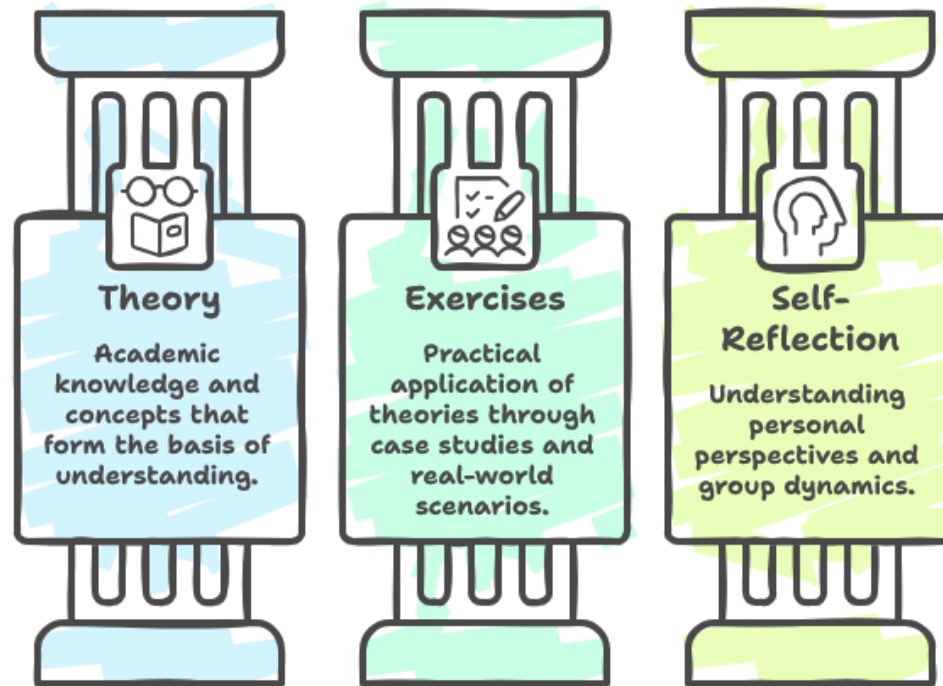


Exercises = Skills

putting the theory into active practice with your classmates.

- Solving **case studies within a team**
- **Applying the theories** to real-world scenarios

How ? Expansion of your competence, cont.

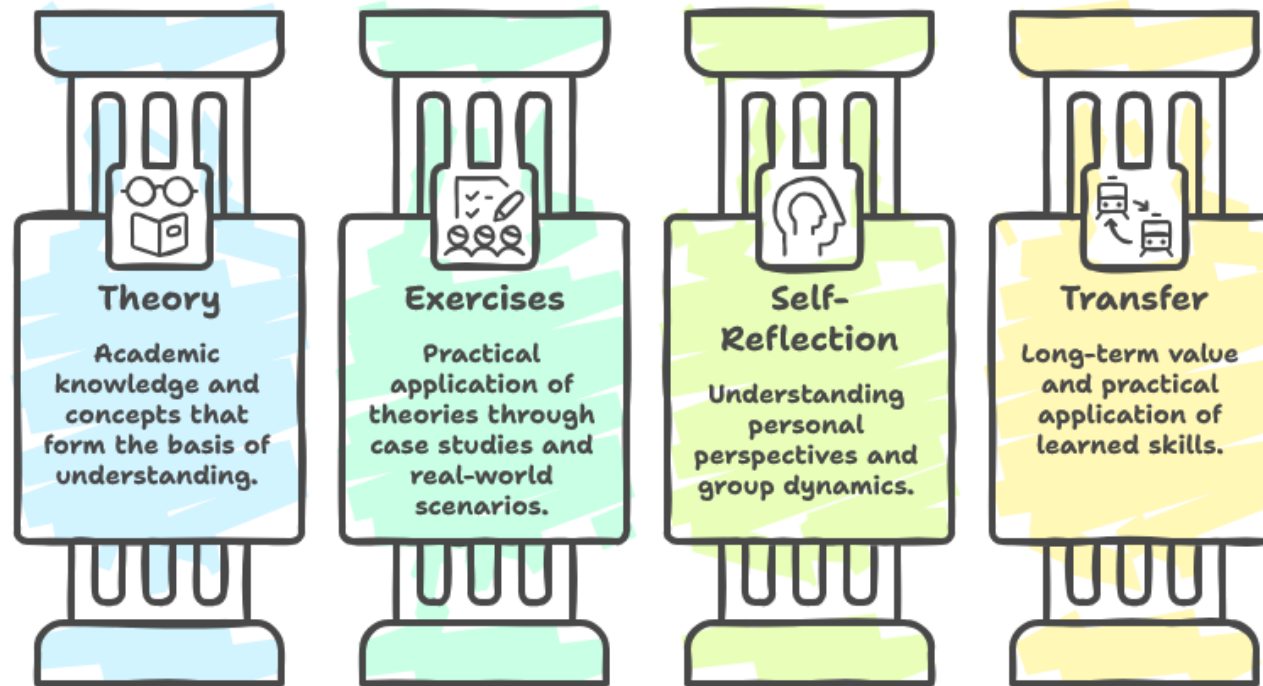


Self-Reflection = Attitude / Mindset

understanding your own perspective and how you operate in diverse groups.

- **Cultural Passport:** An exercise to map and reflect on your own cultural background.
- **Team Roles:** Assessing how you collaborate and function in a group setting.
- **Sociogram:** Mapping and analyzing the communication dynamics and relationships within a group.

How ? Expansion of your competence, cont.

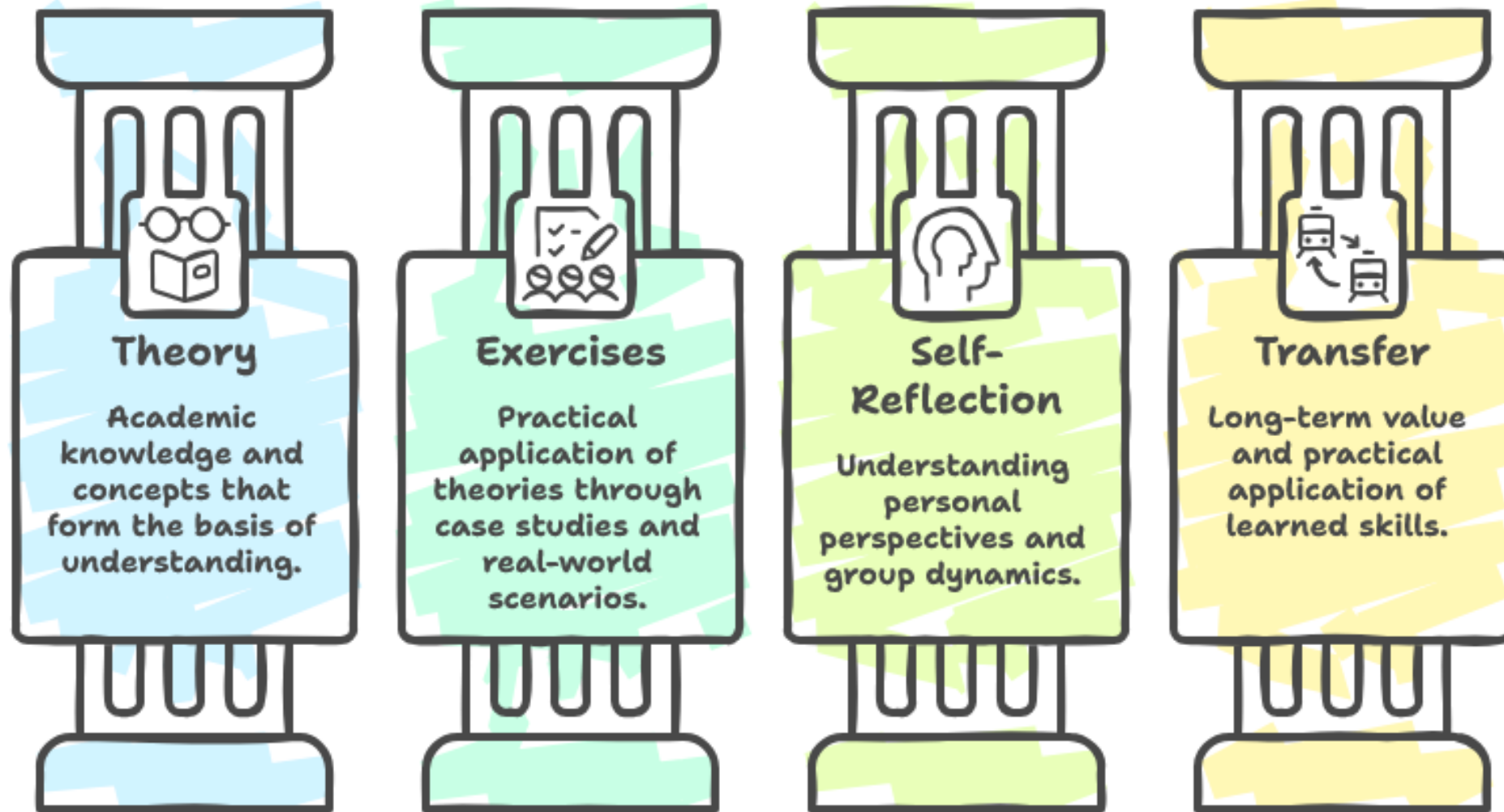


Transfer (Practical Application)

the long-term value of the course, prompting you to evaluate:

- **What are you taking away with you?**
- **What is the practical use of this?**

How ? Expansion of your competence1



By the end of this session, we will be able to:

- Define **intercultural** and **heterogeneous** teams
- Understand the **importance** of **team** diversity in IT and business settings
- Identify **common challenges** and **benefits** of working in diverse teams
- Start developing Groups and the Use case for the course report

A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a diverse group of graduates in black gowns, cheering and throwing their caps into the air. The scene is filled with joy and celebration, with several caps captured mid-air against a bright, overexposed background.

What Are Intercultural & Heterogeneous Teams?

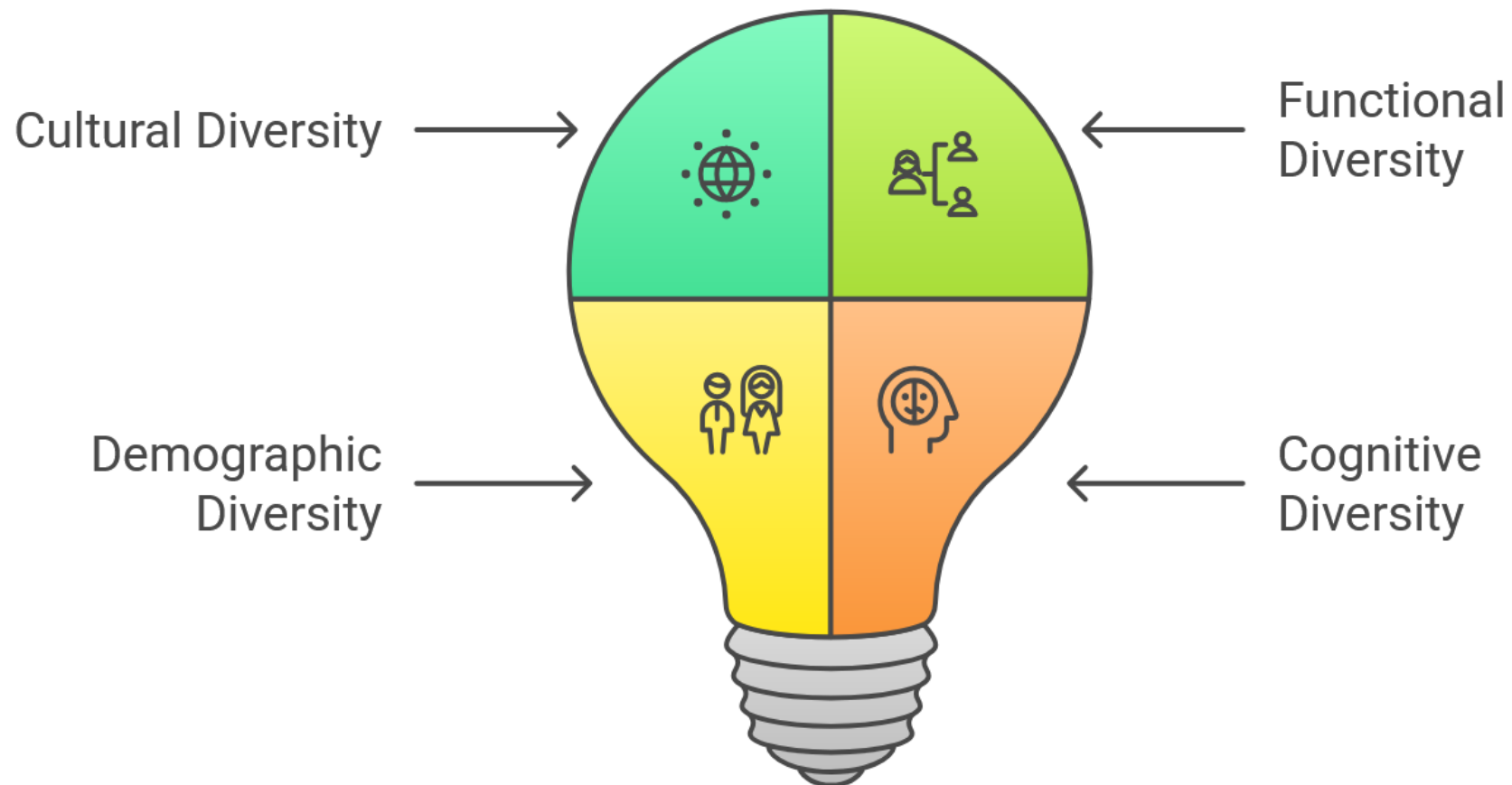
What is Culture?

- Culture refers to **shared** values, beliefs, norms, and behaviours of a group.
- It **shapes** how people **communicate**, **make** decisions, and **collaborate**.
- Culture is learned through **socialization**, not inherited biologically.
- **Example:** Direct vs. indirect communication styles.

Passive vs. Active



Exploring Dimensions of Diversity



- **Cultural Diversity:** Language, Ethnicity, Nationality, Religion

Foundations of Cultural Diversity



Language

The variety of spoken and written communication forms.



Ethnicity

Shared cultural heritage and identity.



Nationality

Legal and social ties to a nation.



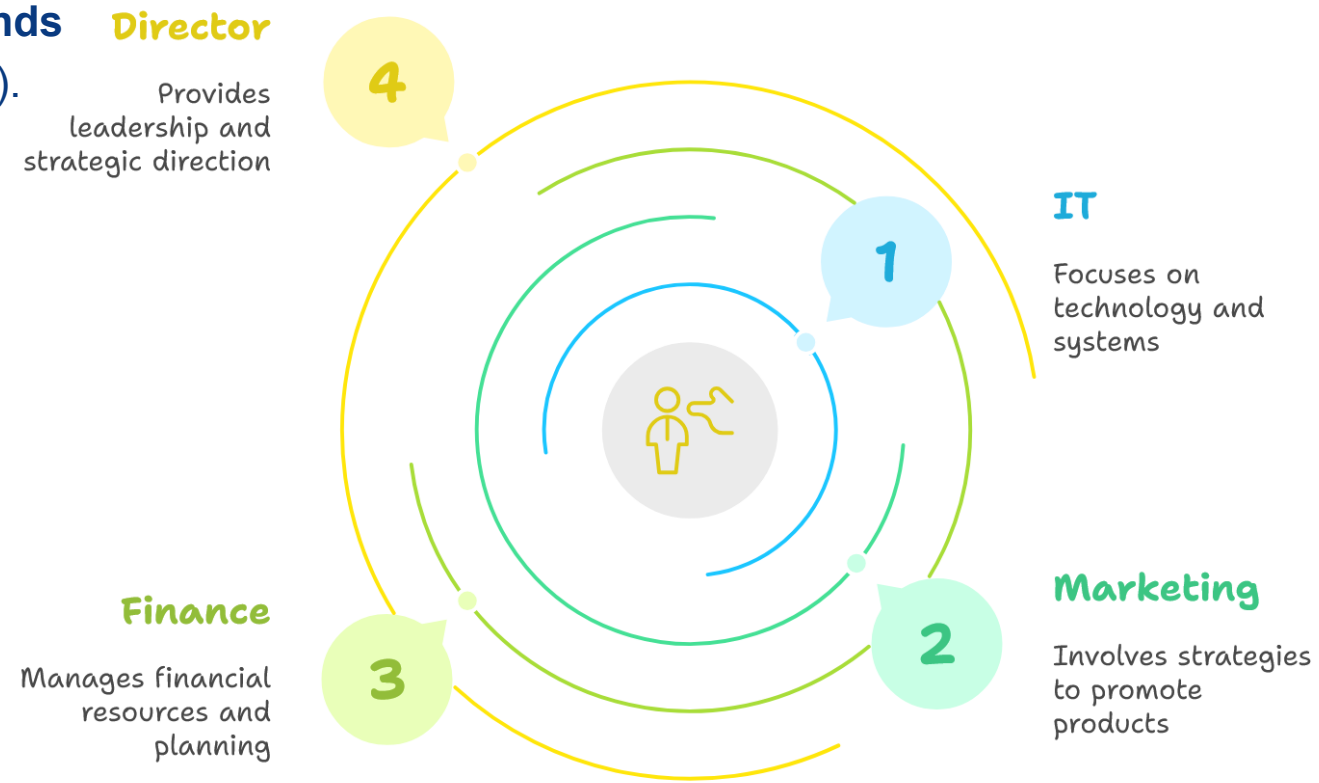
Religion

Belief systems and practices.

Types of Diversity in Teams, cont.

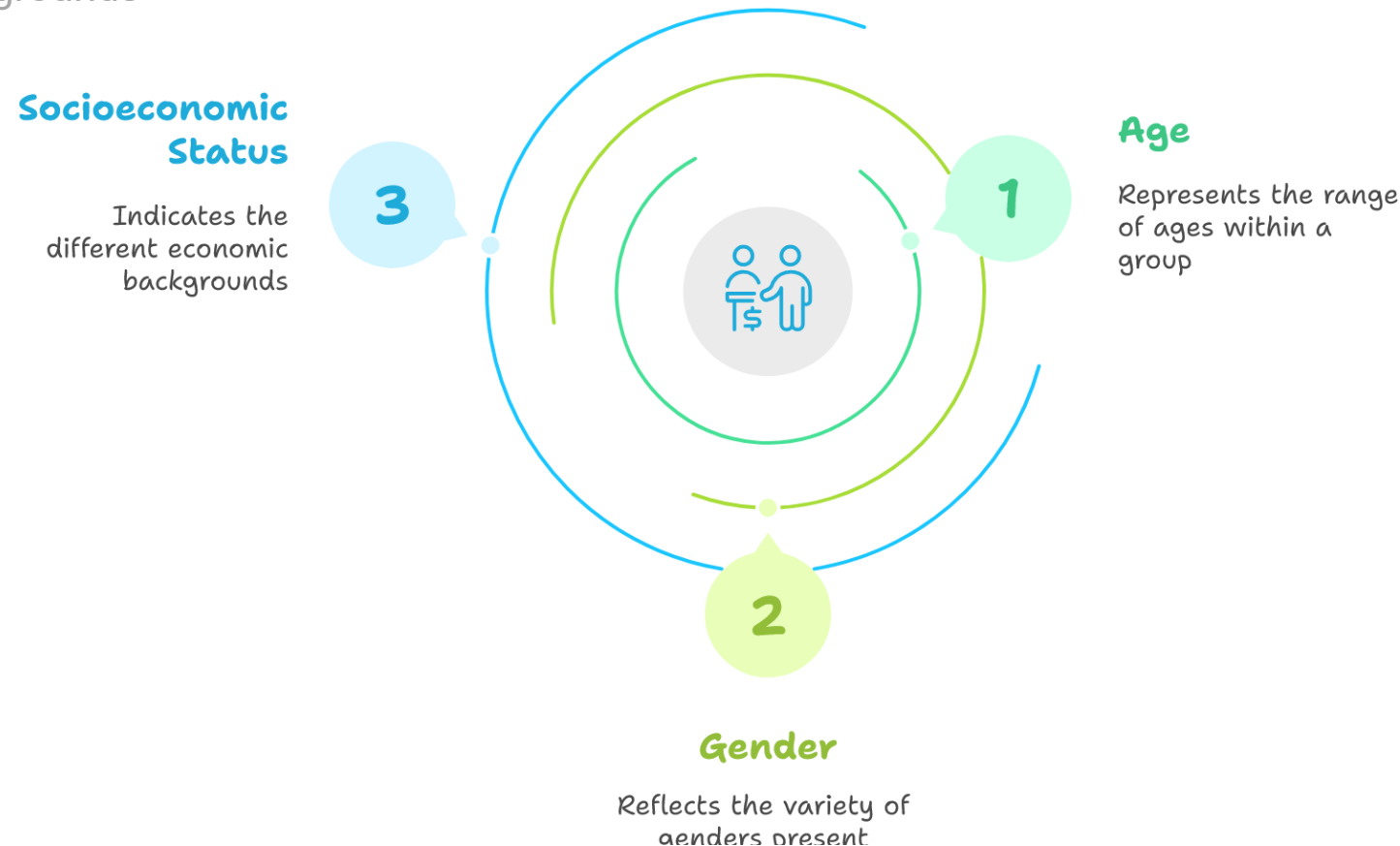
- **Cultural Diversity:** Language, ethnicity, nationality, religion.
- **Functional Diversity:** Different **professional backgrounds** (e.g. IT, marketing, finance, programming, testing, etc...).

Exploring Functional Diversity



- **Cultural Diversity:** Language, ethnicity, nationality, religion.
- **Functional Diversity:** Different professional backgrounds (e.g.IT, marketing, finance).
- **Demographic Diversity:** Age, Gender, Socioeconomic status, ...

Components of Demographic Diversity



Types of Diversity in Teams, cont.

- **Cultural Diversity:** Language, ethnicity, nationality, religic
- **Functional Diversity:** Different professional backgrounds (e.g.IT, marketing, finance).
- **Demographic Diversity:** Age, gender, socioeconomic status.
- **Cognitive Diversity:** Different thinking patterns, learning styles, and perspectives.

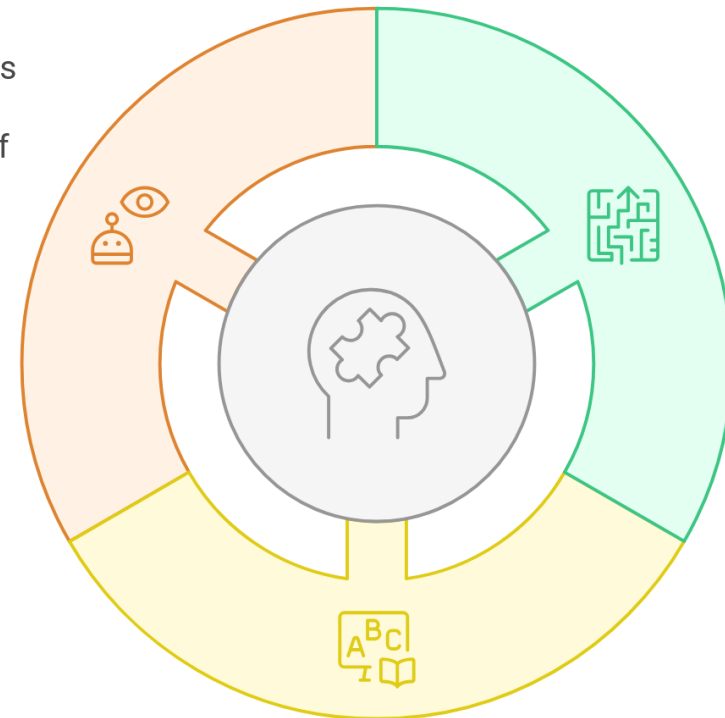
Cognitive Diversity

Perspectives

Unique viewpoints and interpretations of the world

Thinking Patterns

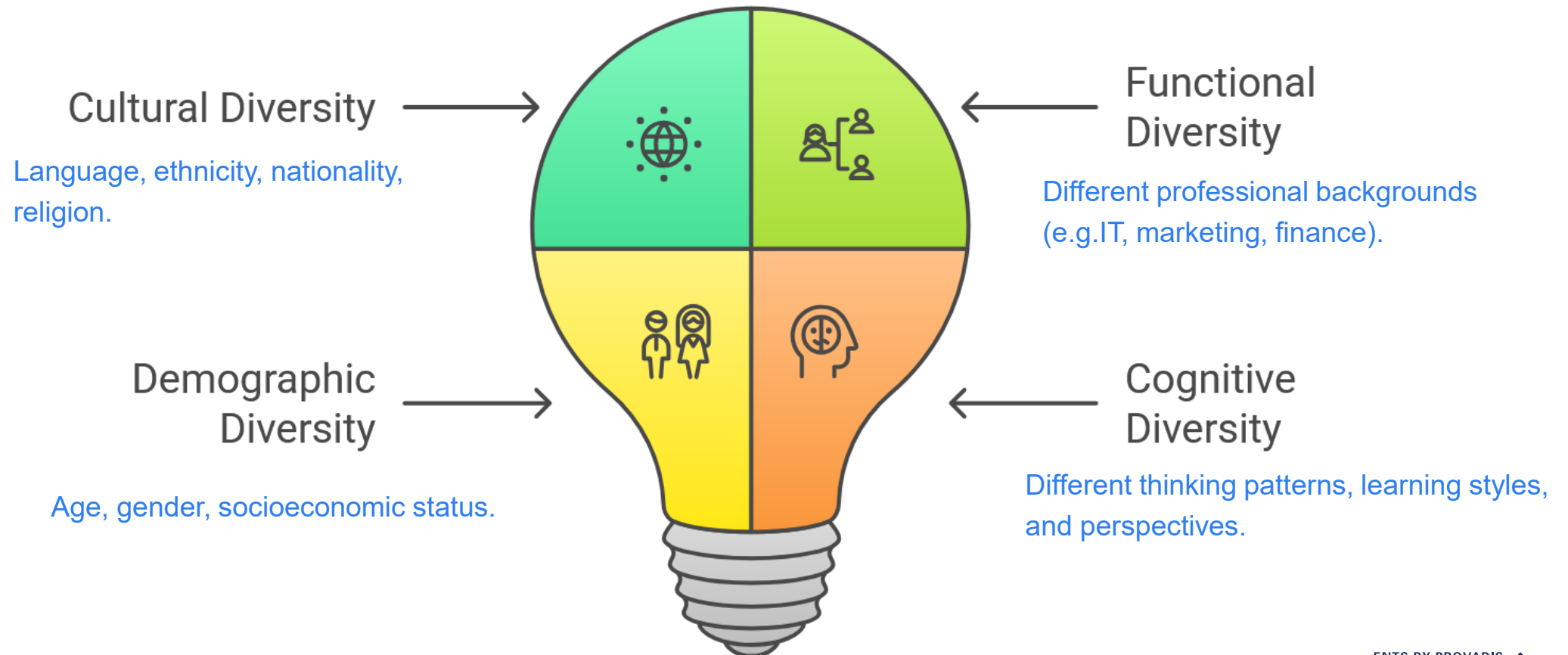
Diverse approaches to problem-solving and decision-making



Learning Styles

Varied methods of acquiring and retaining information

Exploring Dimensions of Diversity



- Comprised of **members** from **different national** or **cultural** backgrounds.
- **Common** in **multinational** corporations, **global** software teams, outsourcing scenarios.
- Intercultural **dynamics** **affect** communication, trust, and performance.



Multicultural teams are those where **different** cultural groups **exist** alongside **each** other, while **intercultural** teams **actively interact** and engage with each other.

Intercultural teams **focus** on **mutual** learning and understanding between **different cultures**, whereas **multicultural** teams may **not** necessarily have this level of interaction or understanding.

Team Composition Spectrum



What Are Heterogeneous Teams?

Pros

-  Diverse perspectives
-  Enhanced creativity
-  Better problem-solving
-  Increased adaptability



Cons

-  Communication challenges
-  Potential conflicts
-  Slower decision-making

- **Encompasses** all forms of **diversity**: cultural, demographic, functional, and cognitive.
- **Benefits**: multiple viewpoints, robust decision-making, innovative problem-solving.
- **Challenge**: requires strong coordination and inclusive leadership.

Why Are Diverse Teams Important?

- **Lead** to **innovation** and **creative** solutions due to varied perspectives.
- **Support** better problem-solving by reducing groupthink.
- Enhance global competitiveness and market understanding.
- Reflect client diversity, **enabling more effective solutions**.

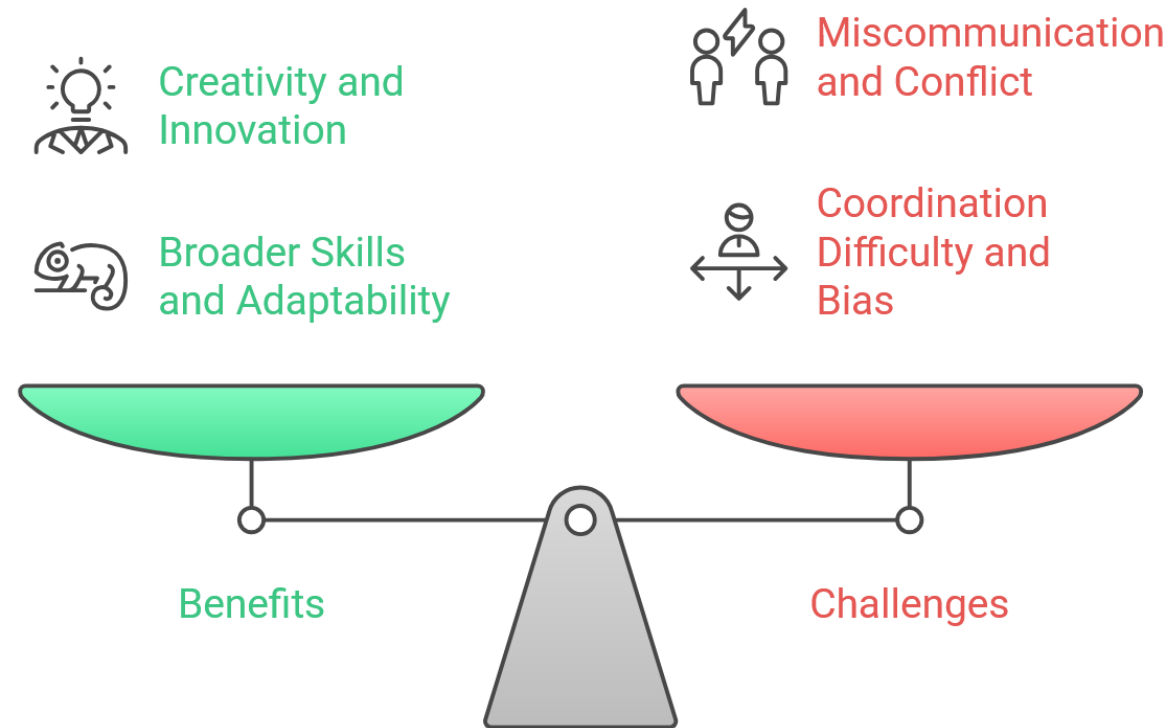
Challenges of Diverse Teams

- **Miscommunication:** Language barriers, tone, body language.
- **Conflict:** Value clashes or misunderstandings.
- **Bias/Stereotyping:** Assumptions based on background.
- **Different expectations:** Punctuality, hierarchy, feedback norms.

Why Do Teams Struggle?

The Balance:

Balancing Diversity's Pros and Cons



Success depends on managing diversity intentionally.

Real-World Example

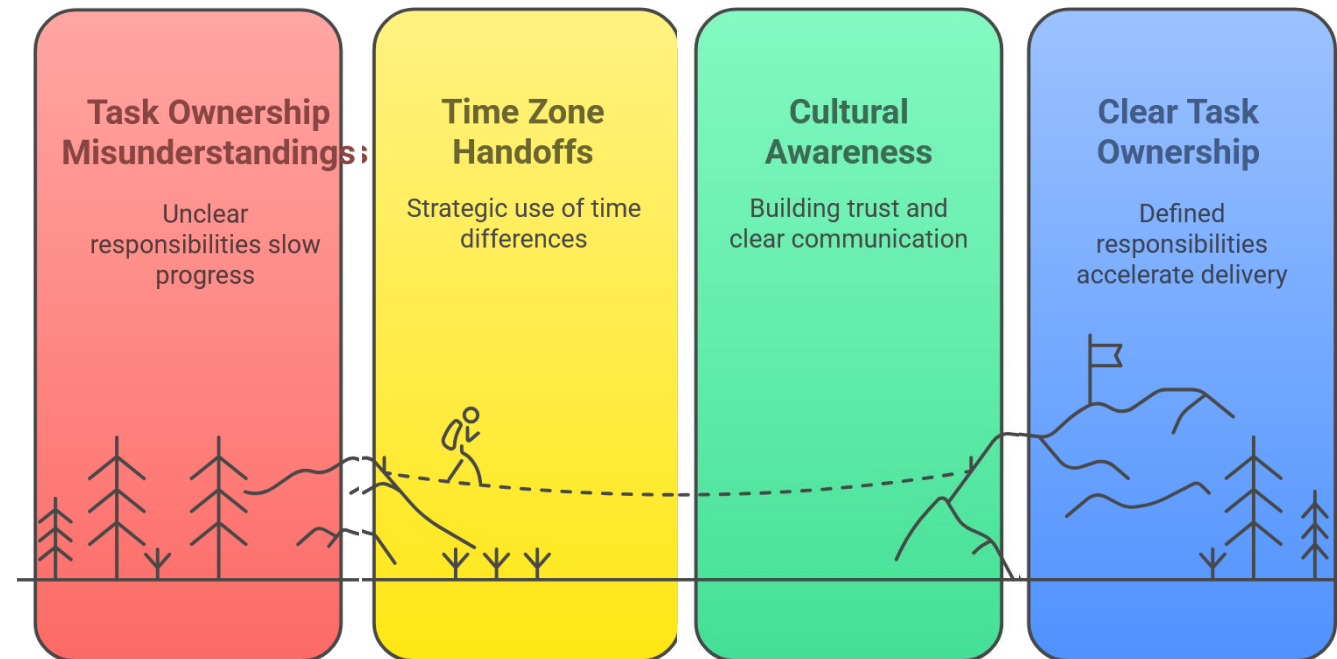
- **Scenario:** A **global** team develops a fintech app across **4 countries**.
- **Team includes** developers from India, Germany, Brazil, and the U.S.
- **What went well:** Time zone handoffs **sped up** delivery.
- **What didn't:** **Misunderstandings** about **task** ownership.



- **Key lesson:**

Cultural awareness helped **build trust and clarity**.

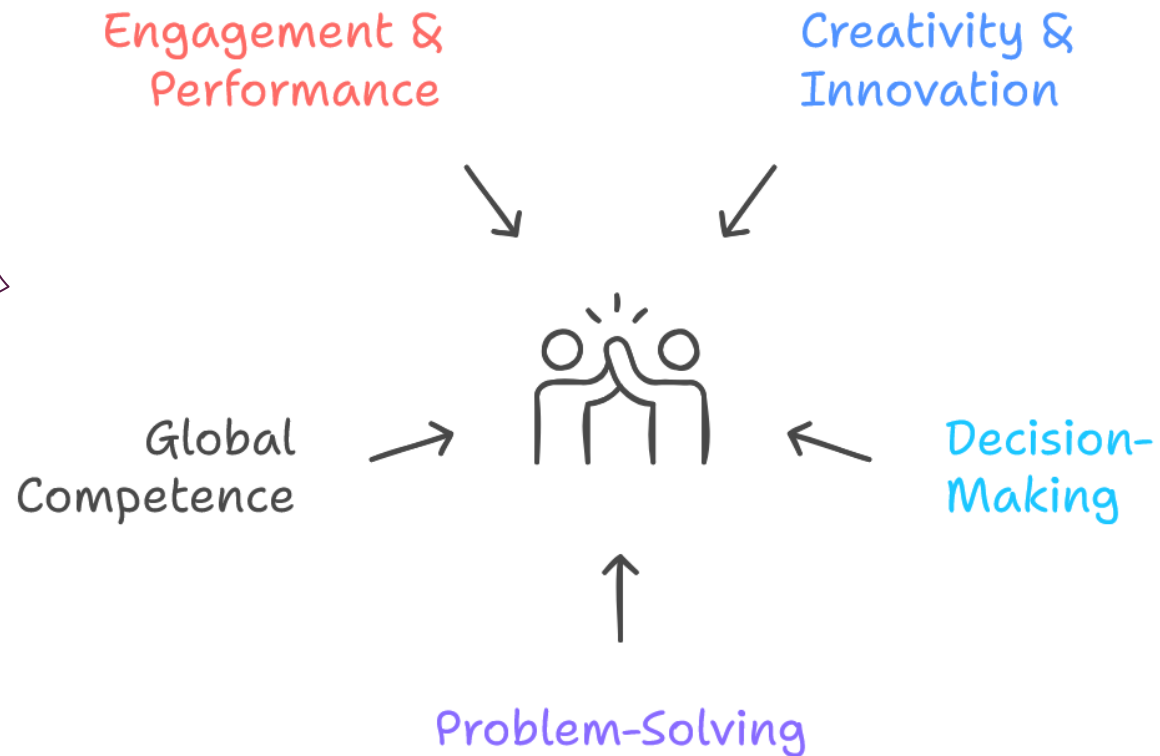
Global Team's Fintech App Development



So why focussing on "heterogeneous teams"?



Benefits of Diversity in Teams



H Teams are a matter of fact, almost de facto, in today's world.

Recommended Readings

- **Harvard Business Review Article: Why Diverse Teams Are Smarter**, by David Rock and Heidi Grant,
<https://hbr.org/2016/11/why-diverse-teams-are-smarter>



Icebreaker: "Mapping Our Diversity"

Groups of 3-6

Activity:

Working in **groups of 3–6** to uncover the unique, invisible backgrounds that shape how your team collaborates.



Phase 1: Create Your Identity Map [5–10 Mins]

Quickly map out your **personal** cultural and identity influences using these 5 categories:

1. **Geography:** Your country, native region, or home city.
2. **Language:** Spoken languages, regional dialects, or accents.
3. **Education & Tech:** Academic background and technical expertise.
4. **Working Habits:** Your preferred workflow and communication style.
5. **Personal Elements:** Hobbies, passions, and unique life experiences.

Phase 2: Group Sharing & Global Debrief (30 Mins)

- **Team Discussion [10-15 Mins]:**
Share your map with your group.
Discuss: *"What specific element makes your cultural experience **unique**?"*
- **Class Discussion [15 Mins]:**
Share your core **team findings** with the class.

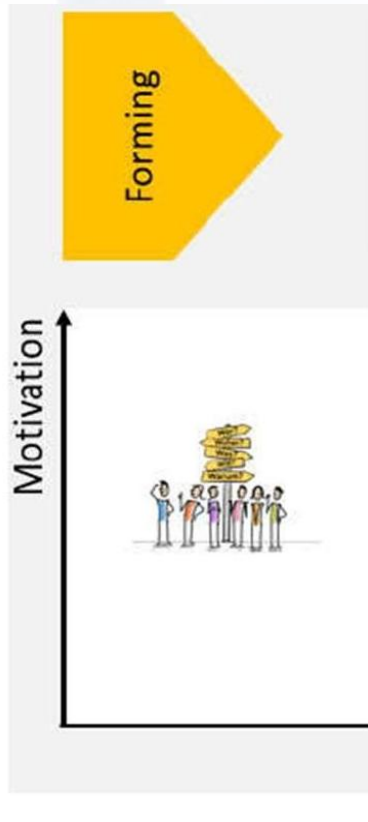


Teams Development Stages



<https://www.revolutionconsultinggroup.com.au/5-stages-of-team-development>

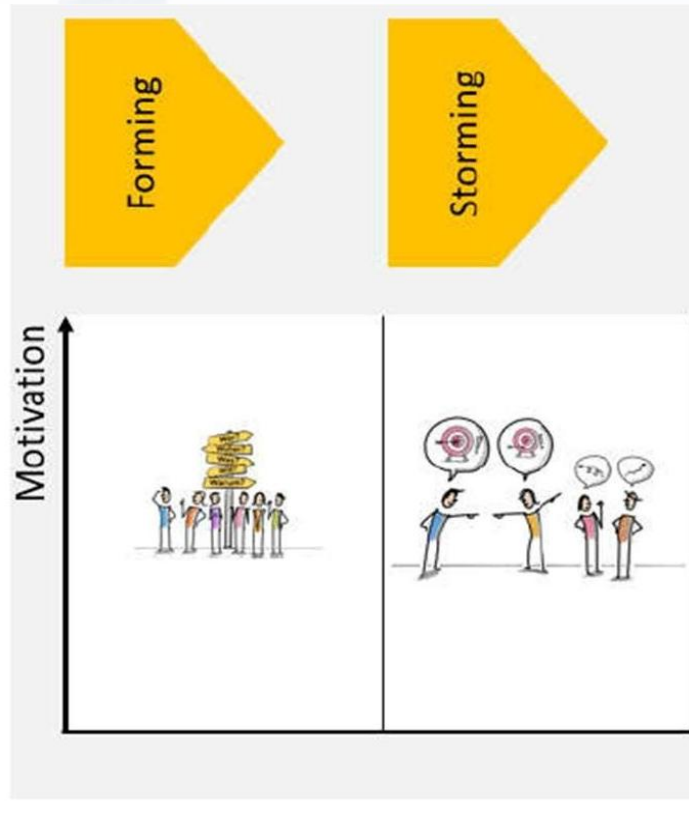
Bruce Tuckman's Team Development:



Forming

- ❑ This is the **initial stage** where team members come together.
- ❑ They are **polite**, **excited**, and **unsure** about **roles** and **expectations**.
- ❑ **Leaders** play a crucial role in providing **guidance** and establishing **direction**.

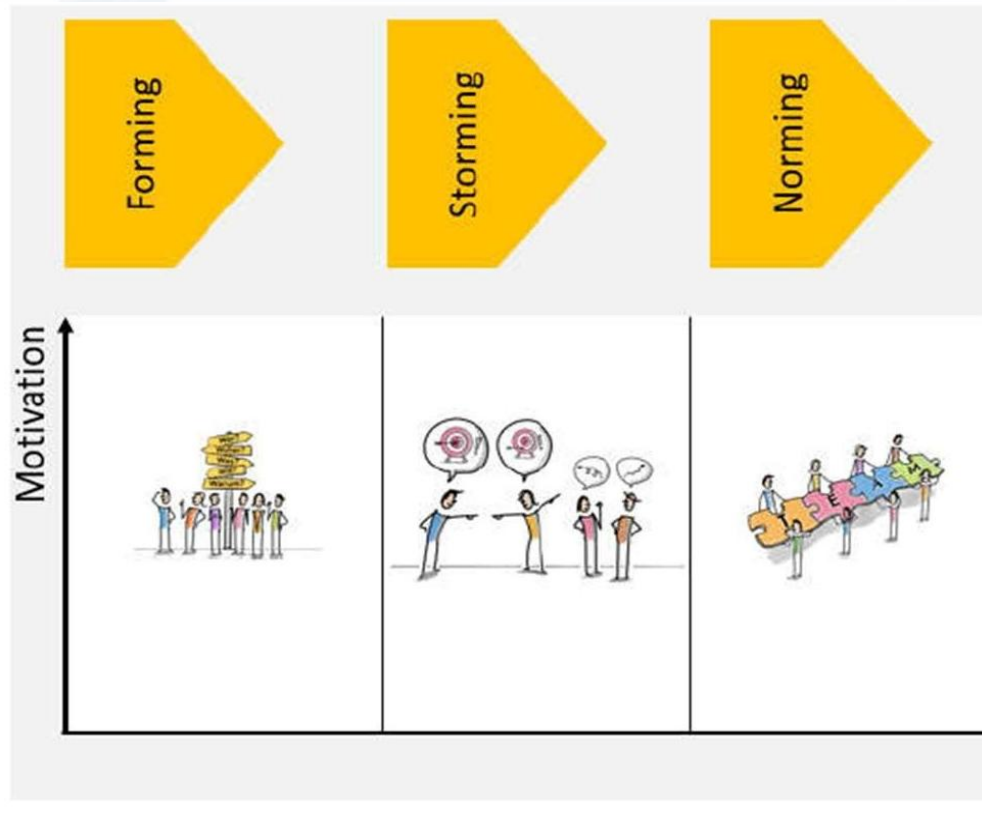
Bruce Tuckman's Team Development:



Storming

- ❑ **Differences** emerge as individuals assert themselves.
- ❑ **Conflicts** over **tasks**, **roles**, and **working styles arise**, leading to **tensions**.
- ❑ This phase can be **challenging**, but **resolving conflicts is key** to moving forward.

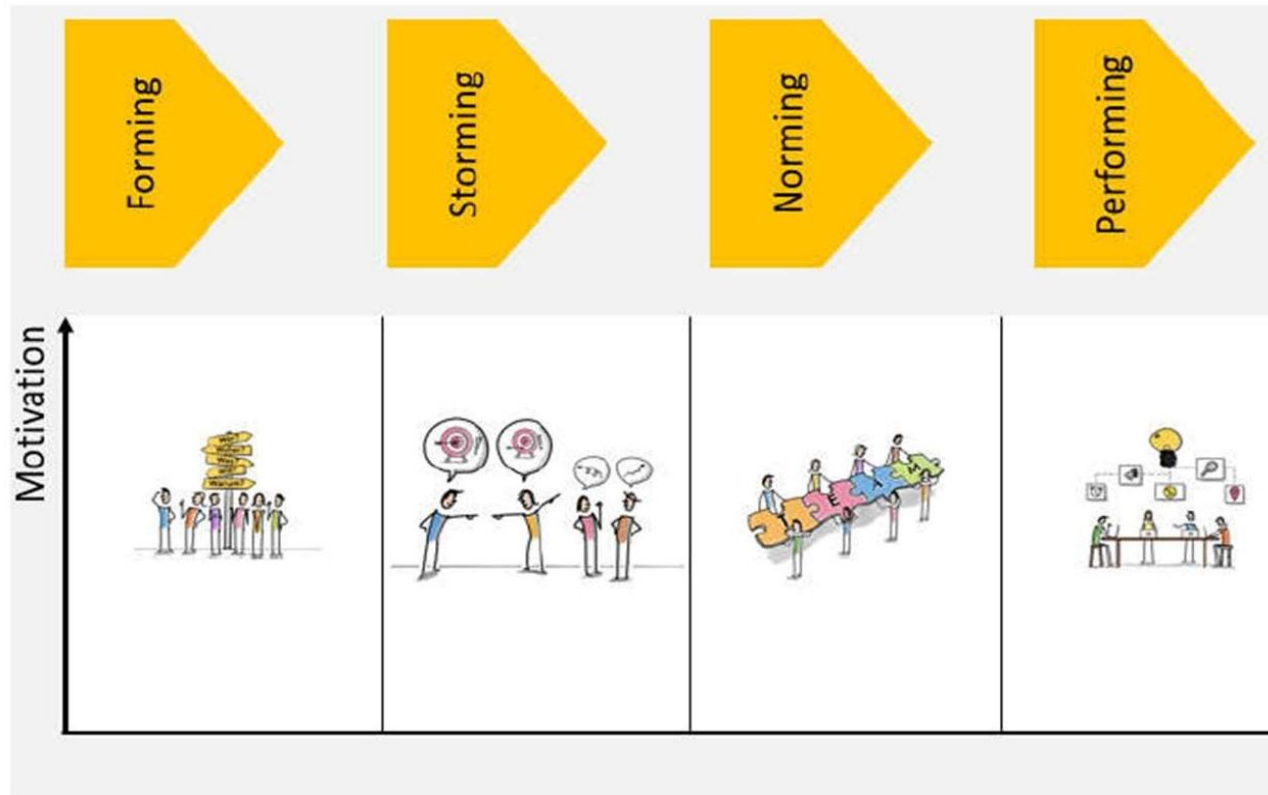
Bruce Tuckman's Team Development:



Norming

- ❑ As **conflicts** get **addressed**, team members begin to **understand each other better**.
- ❑ They establish **norms**, **collaborate** more **effectively**, and develop **trust**.
- ❑ **Productivity starts to improve.**

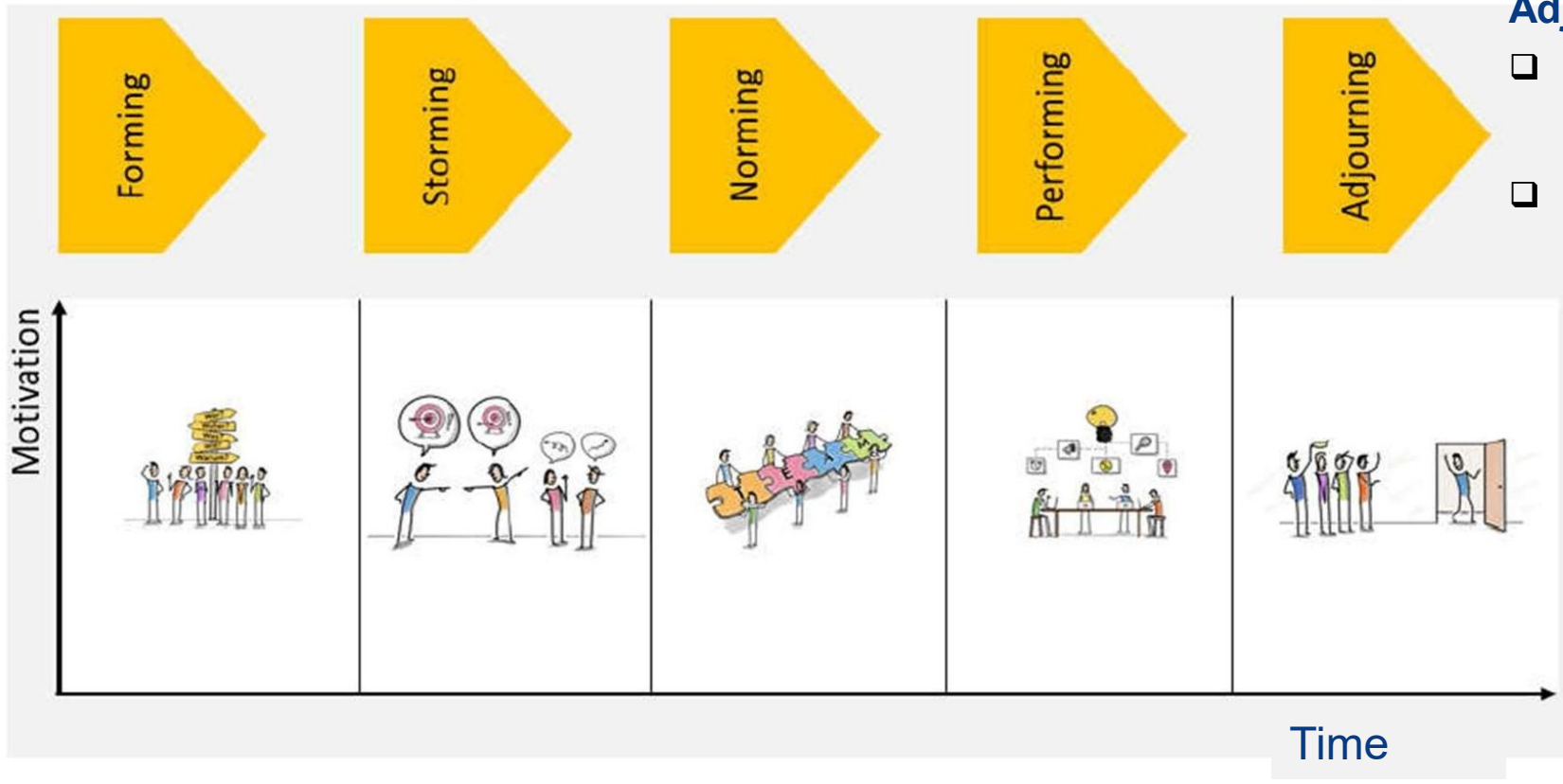
Bruce Tuckman's Team Development:



Performing

- ❑ The team **reaches** its **highest** level of **efficiency**.
- ❑ Members work **well together**, **communication** is **strong**, and
- ❑ they **successfully** achieve **goals** with **little need** for supervision.

Bruce Tuckman's Team Development:



Adjourning

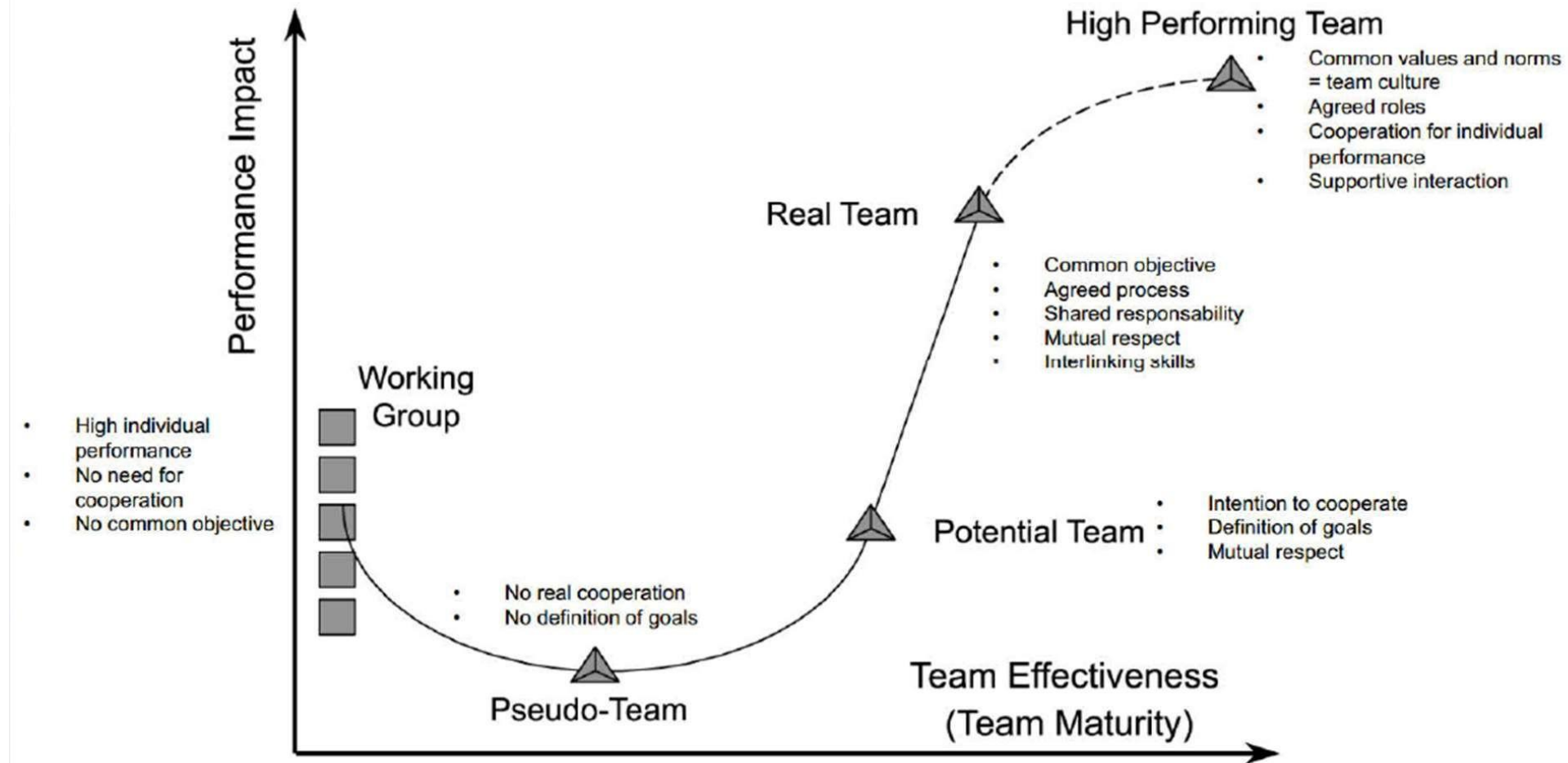
- ❑ As projects **end** or **teams disband**, members **reflect** on their **experiences**.
- ❑ This phase **acknowledges achievements** and **prepares individuals** for **future** teamwork.

5 Stages of Team development



Human competence in heterogeneous teams

Categorise forms of collaboration

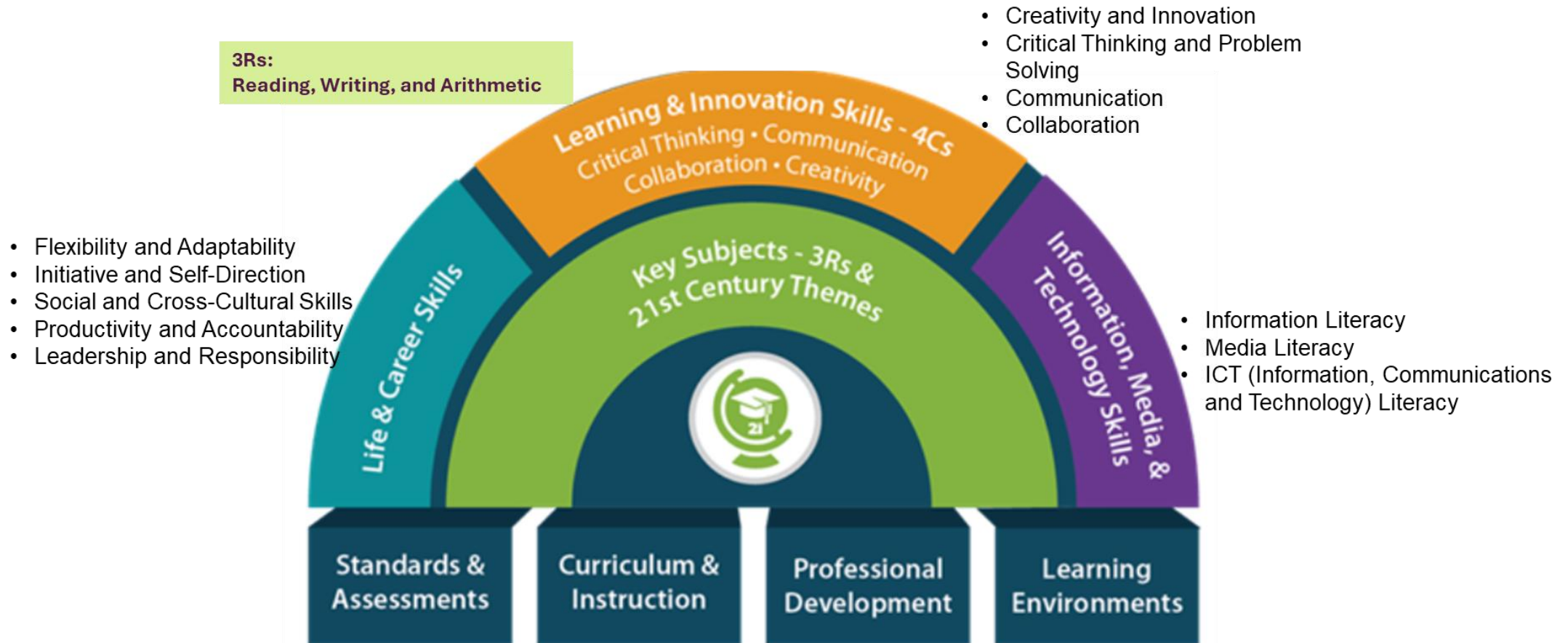


Teams Consists of Human beings

Human Competence in Heterogeneous Teams

Human Factor - terms

P21 Framework for 21st Century Learning



<https://remakelearning.org/stories/demystifying-learning-frameworks-the-p21-framework/>

What does “Human Competence” mean?

- **Self-Awareness:**

Understanding one’s **own biases, values**, and communication **style**.

- **Cultural Intelligence (CQ):**

Ability to **function effectively** across **cultural** settings.

- **Empathy:**

Seeing from others’ cultural perspectives and **valuing different** viewpoints.

- **Adaptability:**

Adjusting communication and **collaboration** styles as **needed**.

- **Collaboration Skills:**

Active listening, respectful disagreement, shared leadership.

- **Conflict Resolution:**

Navigating tension without escalating, with a focus on mutual understanding.

- **Ethical Awareness:**

Recognizing power dynamics, fairness, and inclusion.



- **Critical Thinking:**

The ability to **question assumptions** and **objectively** analyse a problem from multiple cultural perspectives.

- **Problem-Solving:**

Working **together** to find creative, **effective** solutions when unexpected challenges arise.

- **Language & Communication:**

Expressing ideas **clearly** and **actively** listening to ensure everyone on a diverse team is understood.

- **Creativity:**

Brainstorming unique, **out-of-the-box** ideas and combining different perspectives to innovate.

- **Attention Control:**

The ability to stay **focused** on the team's **goals** and manage distractions during **complex** tasks.

- **Memory Retention:**

Remembering and **correctly** applying instructions, project frameworks, or key data during group work.

- **Executive Functioning:**

Managing time, **planning** steps, and organizing **responsibilities** effectively as a team.

These methods are used to **evaluate** skills internally within a group.

- **Self-Assessment**

- **What it is:** **Honestly** evaluating your own skills using structured reflection.
- **Example:** Rate your own communication skills on a scale of 1 to 5.

- **Peer Assessment**

- **What it is:** Getting **constructive**, real-time feedback from your teammates.
- **How to use it today:** Ask your team: *"How well did I **actively** listen during our discussion?"*

These methods are used to test skills through **active** challenges.

- **Diagnostic Assessment**

- **What it is:** A quick pre-test to find your team's strengths and weaknesses *before* starting a project.
- **Example:** Tackle a 5-minute team *puzzle* together to see how you solve problems.

- **Performance-Based Assessment**

- **What it is:** A *practical* task where you physically *demonstrate* your skills in a real scenario.
- **Example:** Analyse a short intercultural business case study as a group.



These methods are used by educators and organizations to formally measure and track competence over time.

- **Formative Assessments**

- **What it is:** Ongoing evaluations during a project to provide feedback and guide continuous improvement.
- **Team Context:** Weekly team stand-ups, project check-ins, and quarterly feedback sessions.

- **Summative Assessments**

- **What it is:** Final evaluations measuring overall success at the end of a project or fiscal year.
- **Team Context:** Annual performance reviews and final project post-mortems against target KPIs.

- **Competency-Based Interviews**

- **What it is:** Structured interviews where candidates describe past behaviours to prove their specific skills.
- **Team Context:** Behavioural hiring questions like: *"Tell me how you previously resolved a team conflict."*

- **Standardized Tests**

- **What it is:** Uniform exams or certifications used to objectively measure technical or language abilities.
- **Team Context:** Mandatory IT/security compliance tests or global language proficiency certifications.

Team Challenge: Thinking Skills Assessment



Cognitive competence, Team Challenge [Slide a]

How do you rate yourself?

Objective: Working in **groups of 3–6**,
pick **3 skills**,
decide **how** to test them,
and **map your** personal goals.

Step 1: Team Choice & Strategy [10 Mins]

- Review the list and select **3 competencies** (skills) your team wants to focus on.
- Use your **Toolkit** (*Self, Peer, Diagnostic, or Performance*) to decide **how** you will test each one.

Step 2: Individual Action & Reflection [10 Mins]

- **Score** yourself honestly (1 to 5) and write down one specific **development goal** [on Slide b].

Step 3: Group Debrief [10 Mins]

- Share your goals.
- Discuss **how** your diverse team **strengths** can **support** each other.

The skills list:

- Critical Thinking
- Problem-Solving
- Language & Communication
- Creativity
- Attention Control
- Executive Functioning



The Action Worksheet

Fill out this table for your team's 3 chosen skills:

 Selected Skill	 How will we test it? (Self-rating, peer feedback, or team task)	 My Score(1 - 5)	 My Personal Goal (What will I improve, how, and by when?)
Example: Critical Thinking	Analysing a team case study	3 / 5	Spot cultural bias in studies by Week 4 by reading extra articles.
1.			
2.			
3.			

Use Case Project Kick-off



Your Use Case Project Kick-off [20 min]

Group Formation & Brainstorming

Objective: Work with your project group to select your target team scenario.

Step 1: Define Your Target Team

Analyse a **real** or **fictional** intercultural / heterogeneous team. Brainstorm and outline:

- **Who is in the team?**
(e.g., *Composition, professional backgrounds, roles*)
- **Where are they located?**
(e.g., *Geographic locations, time zones, remote vs. on-site*)
- **What is their objective?**
(e.g., *The main project, product, or business goal*)

Example [simple]:

- The Team: 3 Software Developers, 2 Quality Assurance Engineers, 1 Business Analyst, and 1 Marketing Lead.
- The Location: Globally distributed across Germany, the U.S., and China.
- The Objective: Developing a cross-border healthcare mobile application under a tight deadline.

Step 2: Choose Your Core Focus Areas

Select **which critical dynamics** your report will **investigate** deeply. Your analysis must address:

- **Team Forming:**
The makeup of the team and their developmental stages.
- **Communication Styles:**
How cultural differences impact information flow.
- **Conflict & Leadership:**
How misunderstandings are resolved and how authority is managed.
- **Collaboration Tools:**
The digital systems and methods used to bridge gaps.

Recommended Readings

- **Harvard Business Review Article: Why Diverse Teams Are Smarter**, by David Rock and Heidi Grant,
<https://hbr.org/2016/11/why-diverse-teams-are-smarter>

Next: Finalize Groups



Any Questions ?